

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 14

POST-MAURYAN ART-IV

- **FAMOUS STUPAS**

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA

- 1 In the period between the Mauryas and the Guptas, the older stupas were greatly enlarged and beautified.
- 2 Of these, three are noteworthy--- those at Bharhut and Sanchi in Madhya Pradesh, and at Amaravati in the lower Krishna valley.



AMARAVATHI STUPA



SANCHI STUPA

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA



- 3 The Bharhut stupa, perhaps in its present form dating from the middle of the 2nd century BC, is important for its sculpture, as the stupa itself has now vanished.
- 4 In the days of the Mauryan emperor Ashoka, a brick stupa measuring about 68 feet in diameter and covered with plaster was constructed at Bharhut.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA

- 5 The carvings depict scenes from the **Jatakas**; the richness and variety of the figures and decorative features strike the observer.



- 6 During the reign of the Sungas, who were in power in the second century BC and reigned till the year 72 BC, a richly decorated stone railing, 88 feet in diameter was added to enclose the mound.
- 7 The representation of Buddha in human as well as in symbolic form is an important feature of Bharhut art.
- 8 Another important feature of the narrative relief at Bharhut is that it is provided with inscriptions, which helps one to identify the scenes.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA

9 Though the figures are too crowded and generally lack expression, Bharhut art makes progress over the simple art of the Mauryas.

10 Nothing is now visible of the celebrated stupa at this Buddhist site other than a shallow depression in the ground.

11 Bricks and sandstone fragments are strewn all around and the remains of the sandstone railing, pillar and gateways that surrounded the stupa have been removed.

12 Most of these artefacts are displayed in the Bharhut gallery at the Indian Museum, Kolkata.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA



BHARHUT SCULPTURES

- 13** Bharhut sculptures are tall like the images of Yaksha and Yakhshini in the Mauryan period, modelling of the sculptural volume is in low relief maintaining linearity.
- 14** At Bharhut, narrative panels are shown with fewer characters but as the time progresses, apart from the main character in the story, others also start appearing in the picture space. Availability of the space is utilised to the maximum by the sculptors.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA



15 Folded hands in the narratives as well as single figures of the Yakshas and Yakshinis are shown flat clinging to the chest.

16 But in some cases, especially in later times, the hands are shown with the natural projection against the chest.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA



MAYADEVI'S DREAM

- 17** Narrative reliefs at Bharhut show how artisans used the pictorial language very effectively to communicate stories.
- 18** In one such narrative, showing Queen Mayadevi's dream, a descending elephant is shown.
- 19** The queen is shown reclining on the bed whereas an elephant is shown on the top heading towards the womb of Queen Mayadevi.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA



RURU JATAKA

- 20** On the other hand, the depiction of a Jataka story is very simple—narrated by clubbing the events according to the geographical location of the story like the depiction of Ruru Jataka where the Bodhisattva deer is rescuing a man on his back.
- 21** The other event in the same picture frame depicts the King standing with his army and about to shoot an arrow at the deer, and the man who was rescued by the deer is also shown along with the king pointing a finger at the deer.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA



RURU JATAKA

- 22** According to the story, the man promised the deer after his rescue that he would not disclose his identity to anybody.
- 23** But when the king makes a proclamation of reward for disclosing the identity of the deer, he turns hostile and takes the king to the same jungle where he had seen the deer.
- 24** Such Jataka stories became part of stupa decoration. Interestingly, with the rise in the construction of stupas in various parts of the country, regional stylistic variations also began to emerge.

FAMOUS STUPAS

BHARHUT STUPA

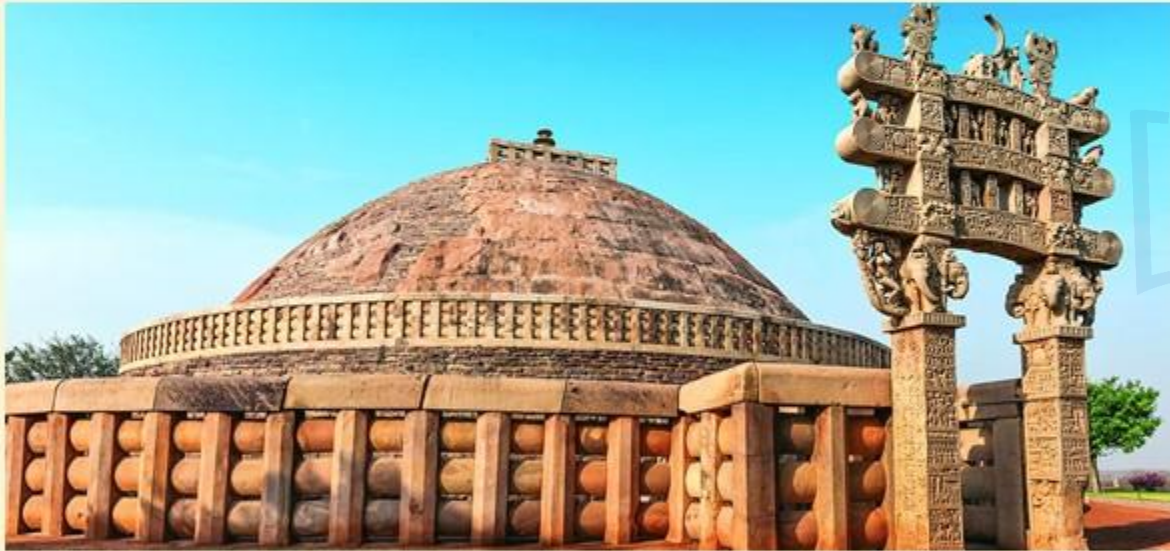


**KNOTTED HEADGEAR OF
BHARHUT SCULPTURES**

- 25** One main characteristic in all the male images of first-second centuries BCE is the knotted headgear. In many sculptures it is very consistent.
- 26** Some of the sculptures found at Bharhut are displayed in Indian Museum, Kolkata.

FAMOUS STUPAS

SANCHI STUPA



1 The Sanchi stupa is, of course, famous.

2 Sanchi is unique in having the **most perfect and well-preserved stupas**, and Buddhist art and architecture pertaining to a period of about thirteen hundred years, from the third century BC to the twelfth century AD—almost covering the whole range of Buddhism.

3 The foundation of the great religious establishment of Sanchi was probably laid by Ashoka (c. 273-236 BC), when he built a stupa and erected a **monolithic pillar here**.

FAMOUS STUPAS

SANCHI STUPA



- 4 It was **enlarged to twice its original size**, becoming a hemisphere of about 120 feet in diameter, in the 2nd century BC, **under the Sungas**.
- 5 It was then faced with well-cut masonry laid in regular courses, and an upper terraced path was added.
- 6 The **old wooden railings** were replaced by **stone ones** in imitation of carpentry.

FAMOUS STUPAS

SANCHI STUPA



- 7 Towards the end of the first century BC, under the Satavahanas, four gateways (torana) were added at the four cardinal points.
- 8 The gateways are remarkable of their carved ornamentation.
- 9 The railings have magnificent decoration, representing stories from the Jatakas , the birth, enlightenment, first sermon and death of the Buddha.

FAMOUS STUPAS

SANCHI STUPA

10 It also contained **historical events connected with Ashoka**, such as events associated with his pilgrimages, villages scenes, palace scenes, forest scenes with elephants, monkeys and other animals, birds and floral motifs, hunters, soldiers, ancient musical instruments with people playing them.

11 The **stone is covered with beautiful carving of a high technical excellence.**

12 The treatment is **simple and naturalistic and shows no foreign element or influence.**

13 There was a **revival of sculpture activity at Sanchi during the Gupta rule.**

14 There are some of the earliest Gupta temple styles which are noted for their well-balanced proportion, restraint in the ornamentation and elegance.

FAMOUS STUPAS

AMARAVATI STUPA

- 1 The Amaravati stupa, which in its final form, **was completed around 200 AD**, had carved panels telling the story of the life of the Buddha.



- 2 The sculpture, beautiful and idealistically treated, showed Buddha as a divinity, receiving worship.
- 3 When excavated by archaeologists in about 1797, **its remains were found to have fallen to pieces**, most of the pieces having been removed through the centuries for building purposes.
- 4 The stupas must have covered about 600 sq.m.

FAMOUS STUPAS

AMARAVATI STUPA

- 5 Its surfaces were carved in the Bharhut style but some features of the Mathura and Gandhara sculptures were also adopted.
- 6 Execution of flowers, foliage, medallions, etc. was very fine exhibiting great vitality of design, exquisite linear rhythm and unexcelled beauty.
- 7 The sculptural remains of Amaravati, known as the 'Amaravathi marbles', have found their way to the British Museum.
- 8 The Amaravati school of art is known for the following features.
 - White marble limestone is the medium.
 - Though nature is depicted, the central characters are human beings.
 - Kings, princes and palaces figure prominently in sculptural representation.
 - The sculptures of kings are not individual statues as in Mathura but are part of a narrative.
- 9 In fact, the Amaravati school of art under its Satavahana and Ishvaku patrons and master craftsmen produced some of the finest art pieces in ancient India.

FAMOUS STUPAS

NAGARJUNAKONDA STUPA

- 1 The stupa at Nagarjunakonda, in Guntur district of Andhra Pradesh, belongs to the Saka-Satavahana period reflecting Mahayana Buddhism.



FAMOUS STUPAS

NAGARJUNAKONDA STUPA



- 2** Excavations have unearthed the remains of a stupa, viharas, chaityas and mandapams as well as some outstanding examples of white marble carvings and few sculptures depicting the life of the Buddha.
- 3** The carvings display a mastery in which detailed ornamentation and elegance of the sculpture are joined in a rare harmony.
- 4** Full homage is also paid to the local cults of yakshas and nagas, as at Amaravati, Bharhut and Sanchi.

FAMOUS STUPAS

LATER STUPAS- GUPTA PERIOD

- 1 Of the later stupas, the two most famous are those of Sarnath (Uttar Pradesh) and Nalanda (Bihar).
- 2 Of the Sarnath stupa, the final form of which dates from the Gupta period, only the inner core remains.
- 3 The Dhamekh Stupa dating back to 500 AD is the largest in the region, and marks the spot where the Buddha proclaimed his faith.
- 4 The Chaukhandi Stupa belongs to the Gupta period. An octagonal tower built by Emperor Akbar to commemorate his father's visit to the place caps the stupa.
- 5 The stupa at Nalanda is also in ruins, giving the impression of a brick pyramid with steps leading upto its terraces. It underwent many alterations in the Gupta and Pala times.

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